Name: **Group:** **Date:**

4 ESO · SEASONS & CELEBRATIONS · ROUTE PRO

Learning Path 4 · Research it right

✏️ Paper worksheet: do the same activities as on the computer. Write your answers and circle the letter of the right option. Do it without notes the first time.

🎯 **My goal**

Before you start: think about your last recall or checkpoint. What do you want to get better at in this Learning Path?

1 Recall: Learning Paths 2 and 3

Type the answers without looking.

1. Halloween is thought to _____ originated in Ireland. (1 word)
2. Pumpkins soon _____ turnips. (took the place of)
3. The custom fell into _____ after the war.
4. A custom presented as ancient but actually recent: an _____ tradition.
5. It was _____ in 1863 that Thanksgiving became official. (1 word)
6. Their _____ (WILLING) to embrace new customs surprised everyone.
7. The tradition is on the _____ of disappearing.
8. We pushed the _____ out for my grandmother's birthday.

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2 Reading: The pagan origins myth machine

A C2 Proficiency-style text (Reading and Use of English, Part 5). Read it all once, then answer. Pay attention to the writer's attitude and to what phrases refer to.

The pagan origins myth machine

Every December, a familiar genre of article resurfaces. Christmas, we are told, is "really" a pagan festival in disguise: the date was stolen from the Roman Saturnalia, the tree from Germanic tree-worship, the whole thing a thin Christian coat of paint over something older and, by implication, more authentic. The articles are shared widely, partly because they flatter the reader with the sense of having seen through an official story.

The trouble is that much of this is, at best, unproven. Historians who work on the period point out that the earliest sources linking 25 December to Christ's birth do not mention Saturnalia at all, and that the decorated indoor tree is documented only from the sixteenth century onwards, some fifteen hundred years after the Germanic practices it is supposed to have absorbed. Some connections are plausible; others rest on nothing firmer than resemblance. Two things looking alike, as any researcher learns early, does not mean that one came from the other.

How, then, do such claims acquire the status of common knowledge? Part of the answer is circular reporting. A popular website repeats a claim from a nineteenth-century writer whose own source was speculation; a newspaper cites the website; an encyclopedia entry cites the newspaper; and the website, updated, now cites the encyclopedia. Each step lends the claim a little more apparent authority, and none of them involves anybody checking the original evidence.

None of this means that the opposite view, that Christmas is pure and untouched, is correct. Festivals borrow; that much is not in dispute. The point is narrower and more useful: a confident claim about origins should prompt the question "says who, and based on what?" before it is repeated. It is a question that serves the student researching a school project as well as it serves the professional historian, and one that is asked far less often than it should be.

1. According to the first paragraph, why are "pagan origins" articles so widely shared?
   a) They are short and easy to read. **b)** They make readers feel they know something others have missed.
   c) They are published by religious organisations. **d)** They are written by well-known historians.

2. What is the writer's attitude to the claim that Christmas was "stolen" from Saturnalia?
   a) It is definitely false. **b)** It is presented confidently but lacks evidence. **c)** It is offensive to Christians.
   d) It is the best explanation available.

3. The example of the decorated tree is used to show that…
   a) historians disagree about the date of Christmas
   b) there is a long gap between the supposed source and the first evidence
   c) Germanic tribes invented Christmas trees **d)** the tree is the oldest Christmas custom

4. "Two things looking alike… does not mean that one came from the other" expresses a principle about…
   a) the difference between similarity and cause **b)** the importance of pictures as evidence
   c) why historians distrust the internet **d)** how festivals copy each other

5. What does "circular reporting" mean in the third paragraph?
   a) news that is repeated every year at the same time **b)** reports that are shared in a circle of friends
   c) information that changes each time it is repeated
   d) sources citing each other so that a claim seems better supported than it is

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6. In the last paragraph, the writer's point is described as "narrower and more useful" because it…
   a) proves that Christmas is purely Christian **b)** focuses only on professional historians
   c) gives a practical habit rather than a conclusion about Christmas **d)** avoids any discussion of borrowing
7. Which best describes the overall purpose of the text?
   a) to explain the history of Saturnalia
   b) to encourage readers to question origin claims before repeating them
   c) to prove that Christmas has no pagan elements **d)** to criticise newspapers for their coverage of religion

3 Real video: why is Christmas on 25 December?

A religious-studies scholar (ReligionForBreakfast) tests the "pagan origins" claim from the reading. Watch it as a researcher: how does he weigh the evidence, what does he concede, and how certain is his conclusion?

🎧 **Why is Christmas on December 25th?** · YouTube video: your teacher will play it for you (youtube.com/watch?v=3DHbOpS-N0c).

1. What does the speaker point out about the date of Jesus' birth in the New Testament?
   a) It is linked directly to Saturnalia.
   b) It is never given: Matthew and Luke do not say what time of year it was. **c)** It is given as 6 January.
   d) Luke gives 25 December, but Matthew disagrees.
2. Why does he say historians have to "piece together" Saturnalia?
   a) No single ancient text describes it fully, and it varied by place and period.
   b) All the sources were destroyed by the Church. **c)** The Romans banned writing about it.
   d) It was a secret festival.
3. What does he concede about the "pagan origins" theory?
   a) It is plausible, because most Christians happily took part in Roman festivals.
   b) It is the only theory historians take seriously. **c)** It is proven by several Christian texts.
   d) It is completely impossible.
4. What is his "biggest" problem with the theory?
   a) Saturnalia was in a different month.
   b) It assumes bishops had the power to impose a date, but most were weak outside their cities.
   c) Sol Invictus was never celebrated in Rome. **d)** Christians did not celebrate birthdays.
5. Why does the 6 January date matter to his argument?
   a) It shows that the Armenian church copied Rome. **b)** It was the date of the winter solstice in Egypt.
   c) Half of early Christianity used it, and there was no Saturnalia or Sol Invictus in the East to explain it.
   d) It proves that Christmas was originally a Roman festival.
6. What is the alternative "calculation" theory?
   a) It was calculated from the Roman tax calendar. **b)** Bishops counted twelve days after the solstice.
   c) Jesus was believed to have been conceived on the same day he died (25 March); nine months later is 25 December.
   d) The date was chosen by a vote at a church council.
7. Which word best describes his conclusion?
   a) triumphant **b)** indignant **c)** dismissive **d)** tentative

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8. What research lesson does the video model best for your research card?
   a) Weigh the evidence for and against a claim and match your certainty to it.
   b) Always trust the oldest source. **c)** Avoid theories that are popular online.
   d) A claim repeated often enough is probably true.

4 Evaluating sources at C2: what exactly can it tell you?

At this level the question is rarely "reliable or not?" but "reliable for what?". Choose the best judgement and read the explanation.

1. A national museum's web page on Diwali, written by a named curator in 2025. You want to know how Diwali is celebrated in Leicester today.
   a) Not usable: curators are not neutral.
   b) Good for general background; check a local or community source for Leicester specifically.
   c) Not reliable: it is not about Leicester. **d)** Perfect: museums are always the best source.
2. A Wikipedia article with 45 footnotes on the history of Halloween.
   a) Reliable: it has a lot of footnotes. **b)** Never acceptable in research.
   c) A useful map: follow the footnotes to the sources it cites. **d)** Reliable only if it has pictures.
3. A diary written by a Pilgrim in 1621 describing the harvest feast.
   a) The most objective source possible, because it was there.
   b) A secondary source, because it was printed later. **c)** Useless because it is old.
   d) A primary source: valuable evidence of one person's view, not the whole story.
4. Three websites say the same thing about the origin of the Caga Tió, but none gives a source.
   a) Check whether they are copying each other before treating it as confirmed.
   b) Reliable if the websites look professional. **c)** False: agreement without sources means it is a myth.
   d) Confirmed: three sources agree.
5. A university press article on Lunar New Year migration, published in 2012.
   a) Unreliable: anything over five years old is wrong.
   b) Trustworthy for the trends it studied, but figures are likely out of date.
   c) Unreliable because universities have an agenda. **d)** Perfect: academic sources do not age.
6. A travel company blog: "Experience the ancient magic of Diwali, unchanged for 5,000 years!"
   a) It must be true or it would be illegal to publish. **b)** Reliable: travel companies know the destinations.
   c) Reliable about dates but not about history.
   d) Its purpose is to sell; the claim about age is marketing and needs checking.

5 Framing: precise, respectful, not exotic

C2 writing about cultures needs precision: who believes what, without exaggerating, generalising or making people sound strange. Choose the best version.

1. Which sentence frames a belief most accurately?
   a) Everyone in India believes in the power of the lamps.
   b) Hindus believe the lamps magically defeat evil. **c)** The lamps make light triumph over darkness.
   d) For many Hindus, the lamps symbolise the triumph of light over darkness.

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2. Which avoids exoticising?

   a) Families gather for a reunion dinner that may last several hours.

   b) The Chinese have a bizarre custom of giving money.

   c) The mysterious Orient celebrates its strange New Year rituals.

   d) Exotic dragons dance through the colourful streets of the East.

3. Which hedges a contested historical claim appropriately?

   a) The custom is pagan. **b)** The custom is obviously pagan, as everyone knows.

   c) Some people think stuff about pagan roots.

   d) The custom is often said to have pagan roots, although the evidence is limited.

4. Which sentence about Thanksgiving represents more than one perspective fairly?

   a) Native Americans are against the holiday.

   b) For many Americans it is a day of family and gratitude; for some Native American communities it is a National Day of Mourning.

   c) Thanksgiving is a terrible holiday. **d)** Thanksgiving is a happy day for everybody.

6 Paraphrase, not patchwriting

“Patchwriting” means changing a few words of a source but keeping its structure. Examiners and teachers treat it like copying. Choose the genuine paraphrase.

1. Source: “Each step lends the claim a little more apparent authority, and none of them involves anybody checking the original evidence.”

   a) Each stage gives the claim a bit more apparent authority, and none of them involves someone checking the first evidence.

   b) The claim has more authority at each step.

   c) As a claim passes from source to source, it looks increasingly credible, although nobody has gone back to the evidence.

   d) Every step lends a claim authority and nobody checks.

2. Source: “Festivals borrow; that much is not in dispute.”

   a) It is widely accepted that celebrations take elements from one another. **b)** Borrowing is a festival thing.

   c) Festivals borrow, and this is not in dispute. **d)** Festivals borrow things; this is not disputed much.

3. Source: “Some connections are plausible; others rest on nothing firmer than resemblance.”

   a) While a few links may be genuine, others are based merely on the fact that two things look alike.

   b) Some connections are plausible and others rest on resemblance only.

   c) Some connections are plausible; others are firmer than resemblance.

   d) All the connections are just resemblance.

7 Credit your sources

*Order: **"Title of the page", website or author, year.** Example: "The Castanyada", Catalan culture website, 2025.*

1. Which credit line is in the right order?

   a) Encyclopedia website 2024 "Diwali" **b)** "Diwali", Encyclopedia website, 2024.

   c) 2024, Diwali, Encyclopedia website.

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2. Which credit line is complete?
   a) I found it on the internet. **b)** "Thanksgiving history".
   c) "Thanksgiving history", History museum website, 2025.

8 Listen: a podcast is a source too

Listen to the LP3 podcast like a researcher: what facts does it give, which ones would you check, and how does it talk about beliefs?

🎧 **Culture Bites: the story behind two autumn celebrations** · If you cannot listen to it, read transcript 1 at the end of the worksheet (twice, as if you were listening).

1. What kind of source is Culture Bites?
   a) a newspaper **b)** a podcast **c)** an encyclopedia
2. Which of these is a fact you can check?
   a) Pumpkins are more fun than turnips. **b)** Thanksgiving is the best celebration.
   c) Thanksgiving became a national holiday in 1863.
3. How long did the 1621 harvest feast last?
   a) one day **b)** three days **c)** a week
4. Who made Thanksgiving a national holiday?
   a) the Wampanoag people **b)** the Pilgrims **c)** President Abraham Lincoln
5. For some Native Americans, Thanksgiving is…
   a) a harvest festival **b)** a day of shopping **c)** a day of mourning
6. What did people use to carve before pumpkins?
   a) apples **b)** potatoes **c)** turnips
7. How does Emma talk about the Thanksgiving story?
   a) She says only one version is true. **b)** She says the story is not important.
   c) She says not everybody sees it in the same way.
8. You want to write “Samhain took place more than two thousand years ago” on your card. What should you do?
   a) Copy it: a podcast is always right. **b)** Leave it out: old facts can’t be checked.
   c) Check it in a second reliable source.
9. Which words show that the speaker is reporting a belief, not a fact?
   a) “people believed that…” **b)** “It lasted three days.” **c)** “It took place in Ireland…”
10. What would you need to credit this podcast on your card?
    a) only the speakers’ first names **b)** its name, the episode and the date you listened
    c) nothing: audio sources don’t need credits

9 Shadowing · Culture Bites: the story behind two autumn celebrations

Repeat part of the listening just behind the speaker, like a shadow.

How it works
Your teacher plays the clip three times: first read while you listen, then mumble the words along, then say them aloud just behind the speaker.

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Emma: Welcome back to Culture Bites. Today: where do two famous autumn celebrations come from? Let's start with Halloween.

Sam: Halloween comes from an old Celtic festival called Samhain. It took place in Ireland and Scotland more than two thousand years ago, at the end of the harvest and the start of winter.

Emma: And people believed that on that night, the spirits of the dead came back.

Sam: Exactly. So people used to light bonfires and wear masks to hide from the spirits. And here's a surprise: they didn't use pumpkins. They used to carve turnips!

10 Talk: can we trust it?

A teammate asks you about the source you found for your research card.

Your task
Answer about your real source with reasons and evidence, and explain what you do when two sources disagree.

1. **Where did you find your information?**

2. **Who wrote it?**

3. **Is it reliable? Why?**

4. **When was it written?**

5. **Did you check the facts in a second source?**

6. **How do you write about people's beliefs with respect?**

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7. **What do you do if two sources say different things?**

Then · Have the conversation aloud with a classmate: they ask and you answer, then swap.

Model
I found it on Britannica, an online encyclopedia. It was written by a historian and updated in 2024, so it's recent and the author is an expert. I checked the main date on a museum website and they agreed. When I write about beliefs, I use phrases like "for many Hindus" or "people believe", so I don't present a belief as a fact. If two sources disagree, I look for a third, more official one, and if they still disagree, I write "some sources say…" and give both.

11 Piece 3: research card

*Fill it in with your group and hand it in individually. Short notes with key words. You need **three sources**.*

Is it reliable? Ask four questions about each source: who wrote it, when, why (to inform, to sell, to entertain) and where it is published.
Model: *Reliable: a national museum wrote it to inform, and it was updated in 2025. · Check it: a shop wrote it to sell costumes, and there is no author.*

Stereotype: *Some people think ___. This is unfair because ___. On our day, we will ___.*

Celebration: what, when and where
e.g. Diwali · festival of lights · Oct / Nov · India and worldwide

Three customs

One food or symbol

Origin (one fact)

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Comparison with a local celebration

How it has changed · how to present it inclusively

Source 1: credit line

"Title", website or author, year.

Source 1: key information (notes)

Source 1: reliable or not? Two reasons

Source 2: credit line

"Title", website or author, year.

Source 2: key information (notes)

Source 2: reliable or not? Two reasons

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Source 3: credit line

"Title", website or author, year.

Source 3: key information (notes)

Source 3: reliable or not? Two reasons

Where do your sources agree, and where do they differ? (one point at least)

Which source do you trust most, and why?

One stereotype about the people who celebrate it: why it is unfair, and how your group will avoid it

Self-assessment

Circle: 1 Not yet · 2 Partly · 3 Mostly · 4 Fully

Every fact is in two sources, and I say which source wins when they disagree	**1 · 2 · 3 · 4**
Notes, not copied sentences	**1 · 2 · 3 · 4**
Two precise reasons for each source (author, date, purpose, channel)	**1 · 2 · 3 · 4**
Religious meanings as information	**1 · 2 · 3 · 4**
I explain why the stereotype is unfair and how our plan avoids it	**1 · 2 · 3 · 4**

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🔁 **How did it go?**

What helped me most?

What do I need to review?

📚 Study guide: prepare for Checkpoint 3 and the final exam

How to study what you learn in this Learning Path, and practice that works like the checkpoint and looks like the exam. The answer key is at the end of each activity.

How to study

🧠 Test yourself, don't reread
Close your notes and try to remember: write the words, say the rule, answer the questions. Then check. Rereading and highlighting feel useful, but you remember much less.
Retrieval practice · Roediger & Karpicke 2006; Dunlosky et al. 2013

📅 Spread it out
Three short sessions of 15 minutes on different days work better than one long session the day before.
Spacing · Cepeda et al. 2006

🔀 Mix it up
Practise similar things together so you learn to choose the right one for each sentence.
Interleaving · Rohrer & Taylor 2007

✅ Check and fix at once
Mark your answers with the key straight away and write each wrong answer again, correctly.
Feedback · Hattie & Timperley 2007

💬 Say why
For every answer, say the reason: "on, because it's a date." Explaining makes the rule stick.
Self-explanation · Dunlosky et al. 2013

😴 Sleep on it
Your brain stores what you learn while you sleep. A short self-test and a good night's sleep beat studying late the night before.
Sleep and memory · Diekelmann & Born 2010

My plan

1. **Today** · Close this page and write from memory: three things to check in a source and five words from Learning Paths 1–3. Then check.
2. **In 2–3 days** · Do "Practise for Checkpoint 3" below. Look at the key and write again what you got wrong.
3. **Before Checkpoint 3** · Go over the flashcards: only the ones you still miss.
4. **The week before the exam** · Do the exam-style practice in every Learning Path, then the Sample exam. Repeat only the parts you failed.

What comes up

Checkpoint 3 (LS1, Learning Paths 1–3 and 5): short gaps, collocations and word formation, one question at a time, about 45 seconds each, no going back and no notes. You do it once, and you must stay on the page: if you leave it, it is sent. It opens the next Learning Path.

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Final exam: the C2 version: listening for attitude and implication, a long reading, vocabulary (multiple-choice cloze and word formation), grammar (open cloze and key word transformations) and a formal letter.

Practise for Checkpoint 3

One question at a time · 45 s

It works like the real checkpoint: 10 questions, one at a time, about 45 seconds each, with no going back and no notes. This is only practice: nothing is sent, you can repeat it, and at the end you see your answers and the key.

On paper: cover the questions and uncover them one at a time, about 45 seconds each, with no going back.

1. Always go back to the _____ source, not a summary of it.
2. The evidence for a pagan origin is _____ (CONCLUDE).
3. Two things looking similar does not _____ that one caused the other.
4. The article makes _____ claims without citing any evidence.
5. Take viral “facts” with a pinch of _____.
6. It is _____ (WIDE) believed that the custom is ancient.
7. The museum is _____ for the accuracy of its articles.
8. On no account _____ you copy a source word for word.
9. Make sure you give credit where credit is _____.
10. The claim doesn’t hold _____ when you check the dates.

Like the exam: Vocabulary

1 point · gaps 2 points

Choose the right word, or type it.

1. The so-called ancient tradition turned out to be a recent ___. [1 point]

a) invention **b)** investment **c)** inspection **d)** intention

2. The writer ___ that the evidence is limited. [1 point]

a) concedes **b)** condones **c)** confers **d)** consents

3. The figures are _____ (DATE): they are from 2012. [2 points]
4. The claim is _____ (VERIFY): there is no way to check it. [2 points]

Like the exam: Grammar

1 point · gaps 2 points

Choose the right form, or type it.

1. People claim that the custom is pagan. CLAIMED → The custom _____ pagan. [2 points]
2. You must not copy sources in any circumstances. ACCOUNT → On no _____ copy sources. [2 points]
3. Open cloze: _____ the evidence is limited, the theory remains popular. [2 points]
4. Open cloze: This is not to _____ that the theory is wrong. [2 points]

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📚 Study guide: answer key

Look at them only when you have finished each activity.

Practise for Checkpoint 3

1. **original** · the original / primary source.
2. **inconclusive** · conclude → inconclusive.
3. **prove** · Similarity is not proof of cause.
4. **sweeping** · sweeping claims = very general claims.
5. **salt** · with a pinch of salt = with doubt.
6. **widely** · wide → widely.
7. **renowned** · renowned for.
8. **should** · On no account + inversion.
9. **due** · give credit where credit is due.
10. **up** · hold up / hold water = stay convincing.

Like the exam: Vocabulary

1. **invention** · a recent invention.
2. **concedes** · concede = admit.
3. **outdated** · date → outdated.
4. **unverifiable** · verify → unverifiable.

Like the exam: Grammar

1. **is claimed to be** · is claimed to + infinitive.
2. **account should you** · On no account + inversion.
3. **although** · Concession.
4. **say** · This is not to say that…

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Transcripts (only if you cannot listen)

Transcript 1 · Culture Bites: the story behind two autumn celebrations

Emma: Welcome back to Culture Bites. Today: where do two famous autumn celebrations come from? Let’s start with Halloween.

Sam: Halloween comes from an old Celtic festival called Samhain. It took place in Ireland and Scotland more than two thousand years ago, at the end of the harvest and the start of winter.

Emma: And people believed that on that night, the spirits of the dead came back.

Sam: Exactly. So people used to light bonfires and wear masks to hide from the spirits. And here’s a surprise: they didn’t use pumpkins. They used to carve turnips!

Emma: Turnips? So where do the pumpkins come from?

Sam: In the 1800s, many Irish people moved to the United States. Pumpkins were bigger and easier to carve, so the tradition changed.

Emma: Now, Thanksgiving. It takes place on the fourth Thursday of November, and this year that’s the twenty-sixth.

Sam: The story usually starts in 1621. A group of English settlers, the Pilgrims, had a harvest feast with the Wampanoag people, who lived in the area. It lasted three days.

Emma: But it didn’t become a national holiday until 1863, when President Abraham Lincoln made it official.

Sam: Today families travel home, get together and share a big meal, usually with turkey. Many people say what they are grateful for.

Emma: It’s important to remember that not everybody sees the story in the same way. For some Native Americans, it is a day of mourning, a day to remember what they lost.

Sam: So both celebrations started as harvest festivals, but they have changed a lot over time.

Emma: That’s all for today. Happy holidays!

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